INCOME: *Women from higher-middle-income homes score highest overall at 55.8, while BPL women are lowest at 43.5, showing how economic weakness reduces personal choice*

Below Poverty Line	51.3	35.7	43.5
Low Income Group	56	39.6	47.8
Lower Middle Income Group	59	43.1	51.1
Middle Middle Income Group	60.7	45.4	53
Higher Middle Income Group	63.3	48.4	55.8
High Income Group	60.9	46.1	53.5
Upper High Income Group	62.3	48.6	55.5

MARITAL STATUS: *Married women score highest overall at 54.1, while separated women are lowest at 38.3, showing how relationship breakdown can weaken a woman's ability to exercise choice*

Married	59.6	48.6	54.1
In a live-in relationship	56.9	40.4	48.6
Separated from spouse	45.4	31.3	38.3
Divorced from spouse	51.6	29.2	40.4
Widowed	52.8	38	45.4
Never married	60.3	34.9	47.6

SOCIAL GROUPS: *Upper-caste Hindu women score highest overall at 54.4, followed by OBC women at 52.6, while SC and ST women are lower at 48.6 each*

SC	56.5	40.8	48.6
ST	56.1	41.1	48.6
OBC	60	45.2	52.6
Upper Caste Hindu	62.1	46.8	54.4

ZONE: *The West scores highest overall at 53.3, while the Northeast and Union Territories are lowest at 48.0, showing the weakest regional position on women's consent and choice*

North	60.3	43.9	52.1
East	58.3	44.6	51.5
West	61.1	45.5	53.3
South	57.8	43.2	50.5
NE & UT	55.5	40.5	48

Perception Score | Experience Score | Overall Score

Perception Empowerment—how clearly respondents understand consent in principle, including 'no means no', pressured consent, withdrawal of consent, marital rape and consent education. The other 10 assess Experience Empowerment—how far consent is respected in lived situations involving intimacy, family, the workplace, online behaviour and job-related autonomy. For each demographic group, the average score across the 10 perception questions is converted into a Perception Score out of 100. The same method is applied to the 10 experience questions to generate an Experience Score out of 100. The final Consent Empowerment Index is the simple average of these two scores.

METHODOLOGY

The India Today Group's Consent Culture Survey was conducted by social research agency CVoter from May 5–20. Computer Assisted Telephonic Interviewing (CATI) was used to reach 6,379 female respondents aged 18 and above across India. Conducted in all 11 major official languages, the sample spread across major districts of all states.

The data has been weighted to match India's known demographic profile. The final data file places the socio-economic profile within +/– 5% of the country's demographic profile, yielding the closest possible trends. The margin of error is +/– 3% at the macro level and +/– 5% for micro-level trend projections, at a 95% confidence interval. Some table figures may not add to 100 due to rounding.

A rigorous random probability sample, statistical weighting of the data in the survey ensures a representative analysis of the local population, benchmarked against the latest census and other available demographic data. CVoter strictly follows the WAPOR (World Association for Public Opinion Research) code of conduct for ethical and transparent scientific practice and has incorporated the Press Council of India (PCI) guidelines as its standard operating procedure.

are more mobile, more digitally visible and better able to name violations. Employment is the stronger practical variable: women in higher occupational categories show the best lived-experience scores. The survey's crux fits in one line: a rural woman with little education but high economic independence is more empowered rather than an urban, highly educated woman without it.

Yet the survey ends on consensus. Around 86 per cent support mandatory consent education in schools and colleges, with most wanting it to begin between ages 10 and 14. Some 85 per cent say they will teach younger girls about consent and the right to refuse.

India's consent debate is no longer confined to whether women understand 'no means no'. They do. It is about whether families, partners, workplaces, streets, courts and phones respect that 'no'. The survey shows a country that has learned the phrase but not yet built the ecosystem that makes it liveable. Closing the gap between knowing consent and living it is the next battle. ■